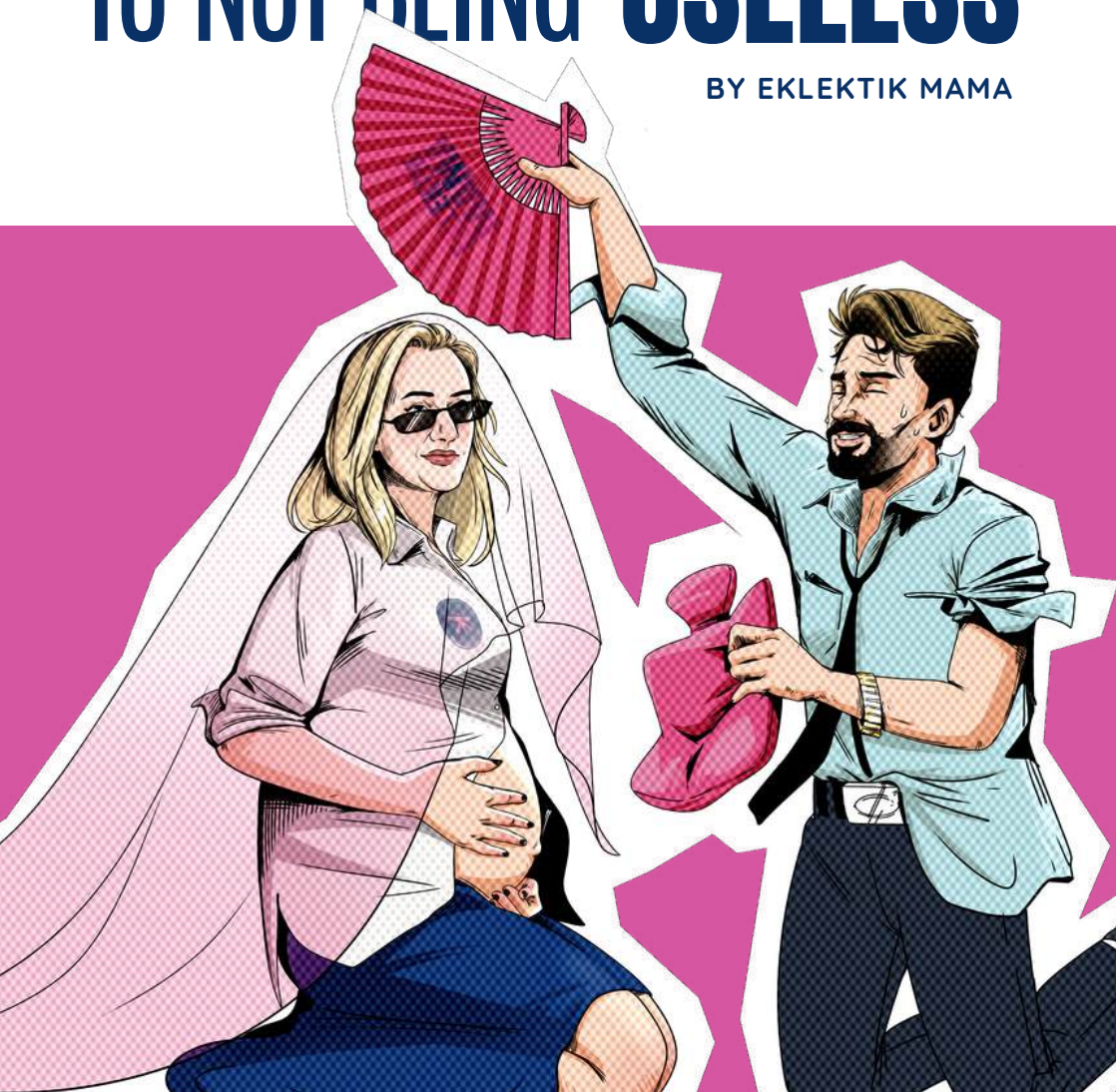




THE PARTNER GUIDE TO NOT BEING USELESS

BY EKLEKTIK MAMA



HI, I'M SIMONE



Founder of **Eklektik Mama**. Mum of four. Straight-talker with zero tolerance for performative parenting.

I wrote this guide to help you actually show up - not just hover. Because you're not background support. You're half the damn team.

This guide is for informational and educational purposes only. It is not a substitute for professional medical, legal, psychological, or financial advice. Always consult a qualified professional for guidance relevant to your individual circumstances.

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No medals. No magic. Just consistency that counts.



BEFORE THE BABY



LET'S TALK BEFORE THE SH*T HITS THE FAN

Before the baby arrives, there's a small window of time when you can still hear yourself think. Use it wisely.

This is your chance to get clear on what life will actually look like once a small human explodes into your world. And spoiler alert: winging it is not a plan.

Here are five areas you must talk about clearly and honestly - before the chaos starts.

Money. Careers. Family boundaries.
You know, all the light, flirty stuff



THINK ABOUT

	MONEY	• Who's earning what and what changes when the baby arrives? • Will one of you pause your career? For how long? • How do you feel about shared finances? One pot or two? • What's your plan for emergency expenses or unpaid leave?
	CHILDCARE	• Will one of you stay home? • Are you hiring help? If yes, who manages them? • What happens when she goes back to work? • What's your stance on nursery, family support or a nanny?
	CAREER PRIORITIES	• Are either of you expecting to keep working at full speed? • What happens if promotions or work travel comes up? • How will you support each other's ambitions long-term?
	HOUSEWORK & DAILY TASKS	• Who cooks, cleans, shops and handles admin now? • Who'll do it when the baby arrives - when both of you are exhausted?
	MENTAL & EMOTIONAL LOAD	• Who remembers appointments, buys birthday gifts, tracks feeds and naps, packs bags, handles family WhatsApp drama? • If the answer is 'her', it's time to rebalance.



**PARENTHOOD IS 90% LOGISTICS AND 10%
WONDERING IF YOU FED THE CAT.**

ACTIVITY PAGE

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THE 'OH SH*T WE'RE GROWN-UPS' CHECKLIST:

MONEY

- ☐ We've calculated our actual monthly income (not just guesses)
- ☐ We know how pay will change during maternity leave or unpaid time
- ☐ We've agreed who's handling bills, budgeting, and tracking spending
- ☐ We've decided how we're managing money: joint, split, or shared pot

CHILDCARE

- ☐ We've agreed how we're sharing day and night baby care
- ☐ We've discussed what help we'll need and who manages that help - family, nanny, cleaner, or other support
- ☐ We've set a timeline for introducing nursery, nanny or daycare

CAREER

- ☐ We've talked about what work changes we're both expecting after baby arrives
- ☐ We're clear on whose career takes priority right now - and that we both agree
- ☐ We've made space for future changes (like one of us pivoting or pausing)

HOUSEHOLD

- ☐ We've listed out our regular weekly chores - laundry, cooking, cleaning, etc.
- ☐ We've compared who does what now vs what's realistic after baby
- ☐ We've each chosen 3 household tasks we'll take full ownership of

MENTAL LOAD

- ☐ List the hidden work: booking appointments, meal planning, finance tracking, soothing family tensions.
- ☐ Choose which ones you'll take off her plate - permanently.

PREGNANCY & BIRTH

THE REALITY

Pregnancy might be happening in her body, but how supported she feels depends a lot on you. Your job isn't to hover awkwardly or ask 'what do you need?' every five minutes. It's to anticipate, prepare and be present.

WHAT SUPPORT ACTUALLY LOOKS LIKE:

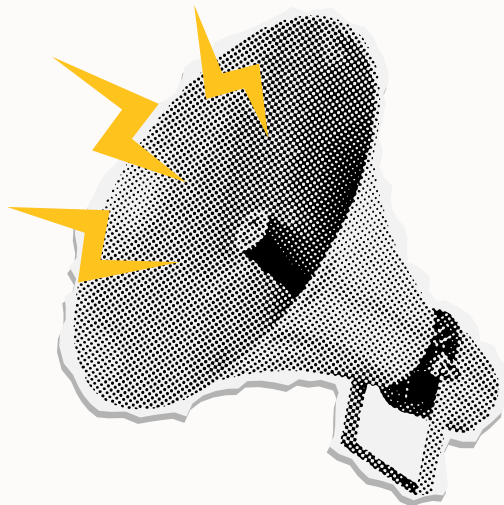
- Be involved. Go to the appointments. Ask questions. Take notes if she's overwhelmed. Know what's going on with her body, her mental health and the baby's development.
- Track the timeline. Know when scans are, when antenatal classes start, and when to start prepping your hospital bag.
- Share the admin. Fill in the insurance paperwork, research hospitals, register for classes, order what the baby needs.
- Do the physical stuff. Carry the heavy things. Rub her back. Cook dinner. If her body is growing a human, your hands better be doing something useful.
- Emotionally show up. Hormones are no joke. She might cry over toast or snap because the air con is too cold. Be patient, not defensive.
- Birth planning is your business. Learn what she wants. Read about pain relief options. Watch a birth video. Know the signs of labour. Understand what advocating for her in the delivery room actually means (spoiler: it's not just holding her hand).

PREGNANCY & BIRTH

THE REALITY

WHEN THE BIRTH HAPPENS:

- You are not a hero for being there. You're a decent partner.
- Be her voice if she's not being heard. Know what she wants so you can advocate with confidence.
- Stay calm. Even if you're panicking inside.
- Do not eat a double cheeseburger next to her mid-contraction. Yes, this needs to be said.
- If she's awake, you are awake.



HER JOB : REARRANGING HER ORGANS TO MAKE A HUMAN

YOUR JOB : CARRY THE MENTAL LOAD, THE HOSPITAL BAG AND THE SNACKS.

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HAVE A PLANING SESSION
GRAB A DRINK, OPEN THE NOTES APP AND GO THROUGH THIS LIST.

APPOINTMENTS & INFO

- ☐ I know the due date and the key scan dates
- ☐ I've attended most appointments so far
- ☐ I know how to spot labour signs
- ☐ I know how to spot for signs of pre eclampsia
- ☐ I know how to spot for signs of anxiety and / or depression
- ☐ We've taken (or booked) antenatal classes
- ☐ I've read the birth plan - and asked questions

PRACTICAL PREP

- ☐ We've discussed hospital options
- ☐ Our hospital bag is packed (mine too)
- ☐ I know how we're getting to the hospital
- ☐ I've done a grocery run for post-birth recovery snacks
- ☐ I've taken over most of the heavy lifting at home

EMOTIONAL SUPPORT

- ☐ I've asked her how she's really feeling
- ☐ I know her biggest fears about birth - and what helps her feel safe
- ☐ I've learned a few pain management techniques (like counter-pressure or breathing cues)
- ☐ I know what it means to advocate for her if things don't go to plan



WHEN THE BABY ARRIVES



THE REALITY

The baby's out - but the hard part isn't over. It's just begun. This is where the myth of 'maternal instinct' lets a lot of men off the hook. Don't be that guy.

Right now, her body is bleeding, leaking, possibly stitched and sleep-deprived. Her hormones are swinging. She might feel elated, numb, anxious or everything at once. Your role? Step in. Show up. Do the work.

HERE'S WHAT SHOWING UP ACTUALLY MEANS:

- Don't wait to be told. Anticipate needs. If there's a full nappy bin, empty it. If the fridge is empty, shop.
- Take ownership of something. Not 'helping' with baby baths. Running baby baths.
- Let her rest. If she's breastfeeding, you take the burp and settle. If she's pumping or bottle-feeding, take some full feeds off her.
- Don't disappear into work or your phone. This isn't a break from real life. This is real life.
- Manage the basics. Clean clothes. Meals. Water bottles. Bottle sterilising. Keeping the house running isn't secondary - it's essential.
- Protect her recovery. C-section? She can't lift. Vaginal tear? She can't sit. Either way, she's healing. You need to carry more of the load - literally and figuratively.

THINGS TO STOP SAYING IMMEDIATELY:

- 'Just tell me what to do'
- 'I'm tired too'
- 'This isn't what I expected'

She knows. She's living it too.

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SURVIVING THE FIRST WEEK OF BABY

Choose at least three roles below to completely own for the next 2 years. Then stick to it - no reminders, no drama, no 'I forgot'

PICK YOUR ZONE OF OWNERSHIP:

- Baby Bathing & Nappy Duty
- Night Feeds & Settling
- Meal Prep or Daily Food Ordering
- Laundry & Household Clean-Up
- Visitors & Family Communication
- Bottle Sterilising & Feeding Equipment Management
- Pet Care (if relevant)

DAILY CHECK-IN PROMPTS (ASK THESE EVERY NIGHT):

- 'What felt hardest today?'
- 'What can I take off your plate tomorrow?'
- 'What do you need - not just the baby?'

Overnight Agreement

MAKE A PLAN BEFORE YOU'RE BOTH ZOMBIES.

Decide:

- Who's feeding (breast, bottle, mixed)?
- Who's on nappy duty and resettling?
- Are you splitting the night or taking turns by task?
- How will each of you get some proper rest?

Example: She feeds, you do the nappy change and settle. Or you take the first stretch, she takes the early hours.

There's no perfect setup - just one that works for both of you.

SHARING THE LOAD



THE REALITY

This is where things often break down - not because you aren't helping, but because you're waiting to be asked, praised or assigned. That's not partnership. That's project management. And guess who's doing all the managing?

The mental load is the invisible layer of responsibility that sits on her shoulders like cement. It's not just doing the things. It's thinking about them and planning ahead constantly:

- Is there enough formula?
- When's the next vaccination?
- Do we need to register at the clinic?
- Has the baby outgrown the newborn onesies?
- Did I reply to my mum's passive-aggressive text?
- Do we have enough food to make dinner tonight?

You don't have to do it all. But you do need to share it - proactively, consistently, without applause.

HOW TO ACTUALLY SHARE THE LOAD:

- Take full ownership of recurring tasks. That means she never has to think about it. At all.
- Notice what needs doing - and just do it. If the nappy bag isn't packed, pack it. If the washing is piling up, start the machine.
- Use a shared calendar or app. Don't make her remind you.
- Back her up with family, childcare, and logistics. She shouldn't be the only one replying to WhatsApp groups or booking vaccinations.
- Respect her capacity. If she's mentally checked out, don't wait for a meltdown to notice.

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MENTAL LOAD AUDIT

Step 1: List the Invisible Work

Sit together and list out everything that's happening behind the scenes. Use these categories as a guide:

BABY CARE:

- Feeding tracking
- Bathing routine
- Nappy stock + size checks
- Medical appointments, insurance, birth registration + passport applications

HOUSE ADMIN:

- Groceries & shopping
- Bills & budgeting
- Cleaning & laundry
- Organising childcare

EMOTIONAL LABOUR:

- Family communication
- Milestone planning
- Remembering birthdays, gifts, thank-yous
- Social events

Step 2: Pick Your Pillars

**CHOOSE 3-5 TASKS YOU WILL FULLY TAKE OVER FROM THIS LIST.
THIS MEANS:**

- You don't wait to be reminded
- You do the thinking, planning, buying, booking
- She never has to even wonder if it's handled

Write your list. Save it. Then check in weekly and adjust if needed.



PROTECTING THE BUBBLE

THE REALITY

Your home in the first few weeks (even months) should feel like a safe, quiet, low-stress bubble. Not a circus. Not a visitor drop-in centre. Not a battleground for family expectations. Your job? Guard the bubble.

When a baby arrives, people will want to visit. And comment. And hold the baby while she bleeds through her pad and tries not to cry from sleep deprivation. This is when boundaries matter most and you are the front line.

WHAT PROTECTING THE BUBBLE LOOKS LIKE:

- You deal with the visitors. Schedule them, limit them, cancel them. Don't let them 'just pop in'.
- You don't need to entertain anyone. Your only job is supporting her and baby. The dishwasher is not for guests.
- If someone upsets her, you speak up. Even if it's your mum. Especially if it's your mum.
- Watch for her signs. If she looks anxious, overwhelmed, teary, or done - end the visit.
- Give her control. Let her decide when she's ready to have people around. Don't surprise her with visitors.
- Back her boundaries. If she says no kisses, no pictures, no 'helpful advice' - your job is to echo her, not excuse it.

It's not about cutting people out. It's about keeping the right energy in.

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THE VISITOR PLAN

Sit down together and get aligned. One conversation = fewer fights later.

Define your boundaries together and agree what you're both comfortable with.

VISITS:

- When do we want visitors to start coming?
- How many visits per week feels okay?
- How long should people stay?
- Are drop-ins allowed? (Yes/No)

BEHAVIOUR:

- Who gets to hold the baby?
- Are we asking people to wash hands?
- Are we allowing kisses on the face/hands?
- Can people post photos of the baby?



SUPPORT:

- Are we accepting food/help?
- Will we ask visitors to bring anything?
- Do we want time completely alone each day/week?

Step 2: Draft Your Go-To Message

WRITE ONE MESSAGE YOU CAN COPY-PASTE WHEN SOMEONE ASKS TO VISIT. KEEP IT SHORT AND CLEAR.

Example:

"We're easing into newborn life gently and keeping visits short and spaced out. Thanks for understanding - it means the world to us right now!"

POSTNATAL SUPPORT

THE REALITY

Once the baby arrives, everyone focuses on feeding, sleep, and weight checks. But she's still bleeding, still healing - and possibly falling apart inside, even if she looks 'fine'.

Your job? Watch her just as closely.

Postnatal depression and anxiety don't always look like sadness. They often show up as:

- Irritability
- Rage
- Withdrawal
- Overwhelm
- Restlessness
- Constant worry
- Saying she feels like she's 'failing'

You're not expected to diagnose her - but you do need to stay alert and stay involved.

WHAT REAL SUPPORT LOOKS LIKE:

- Ask with purpose. 'What's felt heavy this week?' is better than 'You okay?'
- Don't dismiss her feelings. 'You're doing great' doesn't help if she feels like she's drowning.
- Offer presence, not fixes. Hold the baby. Handle the house. Let her rest.
- Normalise getting help. Therapy isn't extreme - it's proactive.
- Lift the load. Support means doing more, not just saying more.
- Know the red flags. If she's distant from the baby, crying every day, or not sleeping when she can - it's time to call in support.

ACTIVITY PAGE

GET EKLEKTIK AF ✨ SHOP DROPS ✨ EKLEKTIK MAMA LOVE ✨ UNFILTERED AF ✨ WHAT'S ON ✨ GET EKLEKTIK AF ✨ SHOP DROPS ✨

CHECK IN WITHOUT THE CLICHES

WEEKLY CHECK-IN RITUAL

Pick one time each week (Sunday night, weekday coffee, during a walk—whatever works). Ask just two questions, consistently:

1. 'What felt hardest this week?'
2. 'What's one thing I can take off your plate?'

No fixing. Just listen, note, and act.

Build Her Support Map

Fill this out together - quietly, honestly.

WHO SHE CAN REACH OUT TO BESIDES YOU:

- Friend: _____
- Professional (therapist, coach): _____
- Family (safe & non-judgy): _____

WHAT HELPS HER FEEL MORE LIKE HERSELF:

- 30 minutes alone with headphones in
- Going for a walk
- Joining an Eklektik Mama gathering (online or in person)
- Watching something ridiculous
- Something else: _____

Three things you'll do regularly so she doesn't have to ask:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

JUST KEEP SHOWING UP

THE REALITY

There's no secret formula. No hack. No shortcut. But this part's simple: the partners who stay engaged, stay kind, and stay consistent make the biggest difference.

Even when it's messy. Even when you're tired. Especially when she is.

This isn't about grand gestures or perfection. It's the small, boring, repeatable things that matter most:

- Getting up when it's your turn
- Noticing the mess and clearing it
- Making her a cup of tea without asking
- Taking the baby so she can nap, cry, or just breathe
- Saying, "I've got this" - and actually meaning it

Support doesn't always look dramatic. Sometimes it looks like folding laundry without a parade. Or biting your tongue when you're both exhausted. Or offering your full attention when she's spiralling - not a solution, just your presence.

THIS IS THE LONG GAME. STAY IN IT.

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YOUR STAY-IN-THE-GAME TOOLKIT

DAILY HABITS (CHOOSE 2-3 TO START WITH)

- Do one household task without being asked
- Offer a break before she asks for one
- Make her something - tea, toast, whatever
- Give a genuine compliment that's not about the baby
- Handle bedtime or naptime routines solo
- Take over more than one mental task (e.g., appointment booking, gift buying, grocery shopping, finances, etc)

Weekly Reset Prompt

Once a week, ask yourself this:

“What did I do to make her life easier this week?”

Write it down. If the answer is “not much,” next week starts now.



Still Here? Good. Stay That Way.

GLOSSARY

Terms You'll Be Glad You Know

Pregnancy & Birth

Birth Plan

Her labour preferences. You don't edit it—you back it.

Lochia

Post-birth bleeding. Not a period. Lasts weeks. She'll need serious pads.

Perineal Tear

A tear between the vagina and anus during delivery. If she's walking like a cowboy, now you know why.

Episiotomy

Episiotomy
A surgical cut made during delivery to help baby out quickly. It's not routine anymore—but if it happens, she'll be sore and stitched.

Mucus Plug

Exactly what it sounds like. Comes out before labour. Not your business.

Braxton Hicks

Practice contractions. Real enough to stop her mid-sentence, but not labour yet.

Waters Breaking

When the amniotic sac ruptures. Might be a splash, might be a trickle. Either way—it's on.

Feeding & Baby Stuff

Cluster Feeding

Baby feeds non-stop for hours. Totally normal. Don't ask "again?"

Let-Down Reflex

When the body releases milk. Can happen randomly. Yes, even in public.

Engorgement

Painfully full, swollen breasts. Think hot watermelons strapped to her chest.

Nipple Shields

Silicone covers to help with feeding. Important, delicate, and always going missing.

Breast Pads

Worn in bras to catch leaks. If you see wet patches—too late.

Formula Prep

Making bottles with precision—temperature, hygiene, portions. Not the time to freestyle.

GLOSSARY

Terms You'll Be Glad You Know

Mental & Emotional Load

Mental Load

The invisible work: planning, remembering, managing. If she always knows what's next—it's because she's carrying it all.

Emotional Labour

The effort it takes to keep the household emotionally balanced—soothing tension, keeping everyone calm. It's work.

Postnatal Depression (PND)

Common after birth. Can look like sadness, rage, or total shut-down. Check in gently.

Postnatal Anxiety

Overthinking, fear, and constant dread. Not just 'being a bit stressed'.



The One to Remember

Fourth Trimester

The first 3 months after birth. Baby's still adjusting to life outside. So is she. Go gently.

Daily Life With Baby

The Witching Hour

5–10pm when baby screams and nothing helps. You're not doing it wrong—it just sucks.

Wake Windows

How long baby can be awake before they need sleep. Ignore them at your peril.

Dream Feed

A feed while baby's half-asleep to stretch overnight sleep. Worth trying. May or may not work.

Contact Nap

When baby will only nap on a person. Mostly her. Offer to take over.

Split Nights

When baby wakes for a few hours overnight and decides it's playtime.

Velcro Baby

A baby who cannot be put down without screaming. Cute. Clingy. Constant.

Blowout

Poop explosion. Defies physics. Travels beyond the nappy's jurisdiction.



LET'S CONNECT

This guide is just the start.

At Eklektik Mama, we're building a space where mothers - and the people who love them - can feel supported, informed and way less alone.

Whether it's events, resources or real talk that doesn't sugarcoat the hard stuff, we're here for it.

Join our WhatsApp Community

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